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Culture (OWC): [Gusii \(FL08\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1974-1976

Coverage Date: Not Specified

Place Coverage: Southwestern Kenya, East Africa

Section Title(S): THE ADULT LIFE COURSE FOR GUSII WOMEN

The young woman as *omosubaati* faces a period of adjustment that is considered by the Gusii to be difficult. She is expected to be exceedingly respectful, quiet, and cautious about violating kin avoidance norms. The "home people" are ideally expected to treat her kindly and hospitably and to make her feel welcome, but they may be jealous of her in one way or another and thus embroil her in controversies before she has developed much support in her new home. Furthermore, her domestic and agricultural skills are scrutinized, and she is criticized, often with mockery, if she is considered lazy, irresponsible, incompetent, or insubordinate. Her progress in gaining respect and social support among women of the homestead and neighborhood depends on many things, including their idiosyncrasies and hers, but in the long run her adjustment requires bearing children early and regularly. As her children grow older, her status increases. The circumcision of her first child of either sex is a joyous event for the mother, a kind of public confirmation of her successful motherhood. When one of her children is married, she graduates to *omongina* (female elder), the highest age grade to which she can aspire. As with the male term for elder, *omogaaka*, however, the use of the term *omongina* within and outside the homestead is distinguished: a woman who is *omongina* through the marriage of her children and through becoming a grandparent (as with men, the confirmation of elder status) is not *omongina* in the sense of the most senior woman in the homestead if her father-in-law has living wives, even though they may be junior wives younger than she in chronological age. Being the oldest chronologically while belonging to the younger generation does count for something, though: people in the homestead may begin calling her *omongina*, saying they are imitating a grandchild who uses the term for the woman who is visibly older.

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As *omongina*, a woman has many prerogatives formerly denied her. She can talk more publicly, even to the point of being raucous and openly aggressive; she is permitted to drink beer at beer parties, though not to sit with the men; she can expect a certain amount of help when she needs it from her daughters-in-law and grandchildren. A  13 woman who gives birth at seventeen or eighteen can become *omongina* in her early thirties and be a

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grandmother as young as thirty-five, when she has another decade of childbearing herself. After menopause, in her forties, she should have circumcised grandchildren, and her primary interests are focused on her son's and daughter's children, some of whom will live with her, visit her, joke with her. At her husband's death, her sons' claims to land will be based on what she cultivated when he was alive, so she is in effect the trustee of that part of his estate belonging to his sons.	554 Status, Role, And Prestige 561 Age Stratification 562 Gender Status 603 Grandparents And Grandchildren 886 Senescence

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